

NUMBERS DRIVE
Enumerators at a Hyderabad house, Nov. 12

MOHAMMED ALEEMUDDIN

BIG QUOTA PUSH

- The survey is aimed at raising backward classes quota that will exceed the current limit set by the Supreme Court
- Of 11.75 mn families to be covered, 2.8 mn urbanites are more reluctant to divulge information, fearing cybersecurity threats
- Among the 75 questions are those about access to places of worship and inter-caste marriage

TELANGANA

A BOLD CASTE COUNT MOVE

By Amarnath K. Menon

The Telangana government has commissioned a comprehensive socio-economic, employment and caste survey that is far-reaching, with the ruling Congress even saying its results will set the ball rolling for an expansion of constitutional rights. The aim is to extend reservations for backward classes (BCs), which would exceed the current 50 per cent ceiling set by the Supreme Court. However, in its early days, the initiative that began on November 9 has met with resistance from some citizens reluctant to share their personal information.

The survey will cover around 11.75 million families, about 2.8 million of whom are in the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation area. However, there is a clear rural-urban divide—those in rural areas are quick to respond despite being busy with farming, urbanites are more reluctant to share Aadhaar numbers, income details and phone numbers. Some have raised concerns following recent alerts from cybersecurity agencies about scammers sending counterfeit links to compromise bank accounts on the pretext of conducting the survey. This makes the enumerators' job challenging. Although the government has set up a dashboard to monitor real-time progress on survey modules, the exercise risks missing the November 30 deadline.



"THE SURVEY WILL BE AN INSPIRATIONAL MODEL, ENABLING THE STATE TO DRAFT POLICIES THAT ALLOCATE RESOURCES TO BENEFIT MARGINALISED GROUPS AND CREATE EQUAL OPPORTUNITIES"

MALLU BHATTI VIKRAMARKA
Deputy Chief Minister, Telangana

The survey, likened by Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy to a 'mega health check', aims to generate data on caste, religion, employment and political empowerment. Among the 75 questions are those about access to places of worship and inter-caste marriage. Reddy has promised to make the findings public, unlike the results of the Samagra Kutumba Survey ordered by his predecessor, K. Chandrashekar Rao, in 2014. The data will be used to plan welfare and development programmes. "The survey will be an inspirational model, enabling the state to draft policies that allocate resources to benefit marginalised groups and create equal opportunities," claims deputy CM Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, while promising that "citizens' privacy will be protected".